regnal titles.[66] Thus, the monumental *minar* was a victory tower in form as well as decoration.

Although the full circumstances of Shah-i Mashhad's construction are not known, it is safe to say that this complex was much more than – or at least quite different from – a victory tower. Surat al-Fath was likely *not* inscribed in its entirety here nor were the quoted verses in cursive, as at Ghazna, where they formed a contrast to the less legible, ornate, or interlocking Kufic of the regnal titles. At Shah-i Mashhad, however, the selected Qur'anic verses from Surat al-Fath and Surat al-Hashr survive in the generally less legible Kufic.[67] In fact, the verses from Surat al-Fath on the south façade actually appear subordinate to the much more ornate and larger, plaited Kufic of the foundation inscription of the central arch, as if building up to the façade's epigraphic apex (Figures 4.1 and 4.6).

Given the Firuzkuh Shansabanis' imperial aspirations – and, arguably, their furthering of these aspirations by patronizing Khurasan's more prominent Sunni *madhhab*s – the inclusion at Shah-i Mashhad of verses from Surat al-Fath appears to be an indexical citation of their reputed predecessors the Ghaznavids. Rather than an *exclusive* "desire to convert the heathen" or to commemorate the recent military victory against the Oghüz,[68] it was conceivably the emulation of an iconic monument and its dynastic context that also led the Shansabani queen Jauhar Malik, Shah-i Mashhad's patron, and/or her spouse Sultan Ghiyath al-Din to choose verses from Surat al-Fath as part of the *madrasa*'s epigraphic program. Ultimately, Shah-i Mashhad accomplished multiple aims for the Firuzkuh Shansabanis: the patronage provided them with an architectural "debut" as patrons of *madhhab*s that were prominent across Khurasan. At the same time, such an epigraphic proclamation also invoked the imperial echelon of the Ghaznavids, who were once illustrious but now were on the wane, superseded by the Shansabanis.

Chisht

Given the proximity of the two surviving domed structures at Chisht (Figures 4.12), it is probable that they originally formed part of a larger complex.[69] This foundation adduces even more evidence in favor of the activity of *madhhab*s other than the Karramiyya in Shansabani-ruled lands prior to the end of the twelfth century.

On the interior surface of the western structure, the cursive inscriptional frieze at the base of the dome (Figure 4.12 [left structure]; Figures 4.13 and 4.14) records in Arabic the renovation (*tajdid*) of the building "in the days of Shams al-Dunya wa al-Din" (see also above). There is little doubt that this personage was the Shansabani sultan Ghiyath al-Din, since the surviving remainder of the inscription continues with his *kunya* Abu al-Fath, his *ism* Muhammad, and *nasab* of ibn Sam.[70] The accompanying